FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The world has lurched into a season of war. If there is a redeeming trait, it is that ceasefires are coming, however tenuous they may be. In May this year, India and Pakistan were engaged in a four-day conflict, with an overhang of nuclear threats. The Russia-Ukraine blood feud that began in February 2022 grinds on. However, the real tinderbox is West Asia. After the dastardly terror attacks by Hamas on October 7, 2023, Israel embarked on a scorched-earth policy of eliminating it, the relentless pursuit resulting in more than 56,000 civilian deaths in Gaza and rendering many more homeless. In the past year and a half, Israel also went after the other key players of the so-called Axis of Resistance led by Iran. It faced off with Hezbollah in Lebanon and the Houthis in Yemen, besides doing its bit to hasten the regime change in Syria.

With Donald Trump returning to power this January, Israel's prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu saw it as an opportune moment to attack Iran, the chief challenger to its cherished monopoly of military power in the region. Trump shared Netanyahu's antipathy toward Iran as also his concern that Tehran was just months away from building an atomic weapon. But Trump initially preferred diplomatic negotiation over military action and set a two-month deadline ending June 12 for Iran to agree to dismantle its nuclear infrastructure. When it failed to do so, Israel launched a massive pre-emptive strike on Iran the very next day, on June 13, using fighter jets and drones to target its major nuclear and ballistic missile facilities. Tel Aviv combined it with hybrid warfare, including car bombs and assassinations. In retaliation, Iran put up a live expo of long-range missiles designed specifically to pierce Israel's Iron Dome.

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Events took on an ominous momentum when Trump decided the US would join the war and authorised unprecedented bombing of Iran's three main nuclear sites using its B2 stealth aircraft, loaded with the mother of all bombs, the GBU-57 Massive Ordnance Penetrators. Known as bunker busters, these could crack through reinforced concrete up to 60 feet and get at Iran's deeply buried underground nuclear facilities, including the big one at Fordow. In response, Tehran threatened to close the Strait of Hormuz, a vital sea lane through which pass about 20 million barrels of oil and gas a day, a fifth of the daily global consumption. Any disruption would have been disastrous for the world economy. Iran also executed an apparently performative missile strike, causing zero casualties, on a US base in Qatar. This is when Trump, whose actions never cease to surprise, enforced a ceasefire as sudden and unexpected as an ambush. It had all the Trumpian trademarks: dramatic, messy in its crafting, perhaps too fragile to last, yet hugely welcome for all sides. Israel, having dealt body blows to Iran's nuclear programme, especially after the US joined the fray, could claim victory but also felt the heat of Iran's ability to breach the impregnability of its major cities, including Tel Aviv. Iran, having demonstrated its missile capabilities, had nothing to lose and everything to gain by returning to negotiations.

But there are many reasons why the truce is tenuous. One stated common aim of both the US and Israel was to finish off Iran's nuclear programme. Far from accomplishing it, Trump's claim of "obliteration" is now being viewed with scepticism, especially after mainstream US media carried American intelligence assessments indicating its military strikes did not destroy core components of Iran's nuclear programme or its stockpile of highly enriched uranium. Though Trump dismissed such reports, experts see it as a reason for continued instability: it is only a matter of time before the US and Israel reset their strategies to tame Iran and resume hostilities. Especially because Iran is now unlikely to allow scrutiny of its nuclear facilities, going opaque as North Korea did on its intent to build atomic weapons. Meanwhile, the direct military action by both Israel and the US sets a dangerous precedent for unilateral action, outside the normative boundaries of global peacekeeping. Such unilateralism could see China justifying occupying Taiwan, as Russia did when it invaded Ukraine. It could also encourage weaker nations to develop nuclear weapons to protect themselves against the new 'might-is-right' global order.

India's links to this conflict are both tangential and direct. Diplomatically, just as with the Russia-Ukraine conflict, it cannot easily take sides. Over 40 per cent of its crude oil and natural gas imports come through the chokepoint represented by the Strait of Hormuz. Conflict in West Asia could lead to a surge in oil prices, costing the exchequer significantly more, which would push up inflation and slow India's economic growth just when it needs to accelerate, besides its impact on the diaspora of 9 million or so Indians in the Gulf, who send back home 40 per cent of our $129 billion global remittances. So, the stakes are high for both India and the world.

Our cover story this week unpacks the global descent into conflict, marked by sporadic peacemaking efforts, and examines how it may unfold in the future. Currently, it's a bizarre situation in which the US, Israel and Iran have all declared victory. America claims to have destroyed Iran's nuclear capability, Israel says it has broken the Axis of Evil, Iran boasts about its attack on US bases and piercing of Israel's famed Iron Dome. But the future of Iran's nuclear programme, the whole purpose of the war, remains opaque. The fate of the region hangs in the balance. Hopefully, better sense will prevail, although it seems a rare commodity in these times of global strife.

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